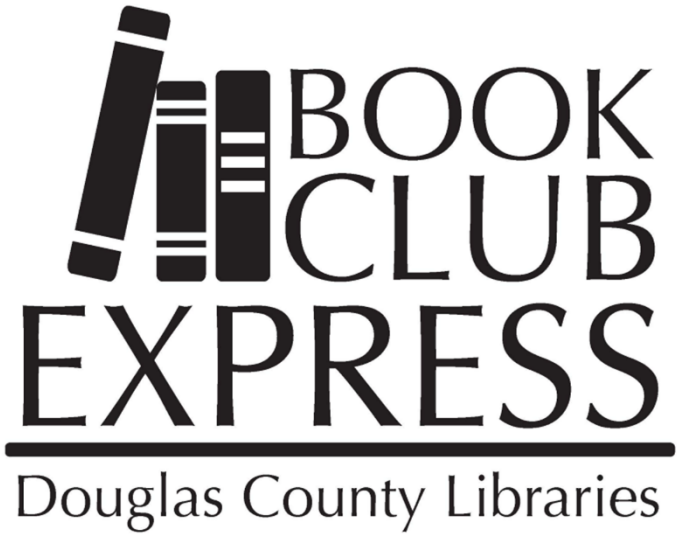

Raising Hare : A Memoir

by Chloe Dalton

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Discussion Questions

1. What is the difference between a pet and Dalton's relationship with Hare? How are both of those relationships different again to, for example, a farmer's livestock, or horses at a riding stable?

2. How effective do you think Dalton was in her aim of keeping Hare wild?

3. Can animals ever be truly owned? Should they be?

4. Has this book made you feel differently about the concept of keeping animals as pets?

5. Dalton describes 'a new spirit of attentiveness to nature' as a result of being with Hare. Have you ever experienced something like this yourself?

6. Did you find Raising Hare to be an emotional read? Did you chuckle at times, or find it sad, heartwarming, or adorable? Why, or why not?

7. What was your view about the ways Dalton talked about farming practices in her area, like hedge cutting, or the use of tractors? Did you agree, or do you have a different view?

8. Dalton says: 'I had rediscovered the pleasure of attachment to a place and the contentment that can be derived from exploring it fully, rather than constantly seeking ways to leave it and believing that satisfaction can only lie in novel experiences.' Do you think we are, as a society, too focused on 'novel experiences'? Should we care for our immediate environments more?

Author Interview

Chloe Dalton on 'Raising Hare'

'It's freed me up to be gentler, more patient and more attentive to my surroundings'

Interview by Erica Ciccarone

Chloe Dalton shares how writing a memoir about raising a wild hare taught her to be true to her own nature.

What do you love most about your memoir?

I wrote the book with the hare stretched out on her side in my office, or licking her paws beside me. As I settled at my desk in the morning to write, she would arrive back from her nocturnal wanderings, shake the dew from her fur and settle down to rest. I never knew what the next day would bring, and it filled me with a sense of wonder. If I'd been writing about an experience that was already in the past, there might have been a temptation to burnish it with my own interpretation and the benefit of hindsight. Instead, my task was to observe closely, to listen and to try faithfully to describe what I witnessed.

What kind of reader do you think will most appreciate or enjoy your book?

I'm not a scientist or conservationist; I'm a city dweller who happened to have an extraordinary experience with a wild animal. I hope that the book might appeal to people who wouldn't normally read nature writing. Perhaps readers who, like me, had a strong connection to animals in their childhood but lost sight of that because of work stress and responsibility. Or anyone who is going through a difficult period in their life and feels uncertain about the future. The message of the book is that sometimes the most beautiful experiences in life are just around the corner, or—in this case—just at the end of the garden. The things that we least expect can end up bringing us the greatest joy.

At what point did you know this story was a book?

When the hare was 4 months old, she learned to leap the wall around the garden. She melted invisibly into the landscape of fields and woods, and I thought she was gone forever. But instead she returned, of her own accord, and chose to live a dual life between the wild and my

home. The fact that she felt so safe in my house that she wished to return was deeply moving. At that point, I knew I was witnessing something very unusual, and that I wanted to document the story for myself and for others.

What was the hardest memory to get on the page?

There is a painful moment in the story when a beautiful young leveret—one of the hare's own young—dies unexpectedly. I was deep in the book at this point, writing the story as it unfolded around me. I was

devastated by its death, and it was a struggle to avoid letting my emotions swamp the page. I could hardly see for tears.

Was there anything that surprised you as you wrote?

I was surprised by how much action and interest there is in the life of a hare. And I could never have imagined that I could experience such curiosity, interest, joy and satisfaction from living alongside a family of wild animals. Trying to find the words to describe the color and pattern of her fur, watching her conceal herself from predators in the garden, waiting for her young to emerge at night so she could feed them, all these moments captivated me. I was utterly absorbed, and felt more at peace than at any other point in my life.

How do you feel now that you've put this story to the page?

I feel closer to nature, more attuned to animals and particularly conscious of the vulnerable lives lived by our remaining wild creatures. The hare is an animal that has never been domesticated. It clings on, despite the destruction of the natural landscape. It is a symbol of beauty, resilience and survival against the odds. This experience has made me more hopeful about the possibility of finding a better balance between humans and nature, and the rewards for all of us if we can manage that.

How have you changed since you started writing the book?

I'd developed a bit of a carapace in order to cope with my work in politics. This experience has allowed me to shed that, and to live in a way that is truer to my own nature. It's freed me up to be gentler, more patient and more attentive to my surroundings. I'm kinder to myself, and able to give more time to others.

What is the most interesting thing you had to research in order to write this book?

Hares have the very rare ability to carry two separate pregnancies at the same time—a phenomenon known as superfetation. I had the privilege of watching this happen in real life. I then read every study I could find, to understand this extraordinary, and rather controversial, aspect of a hare's biology. It was also very enjoyable simply trying to pin down the exact differences between rabbits and hares. Before I met the hare, I couldn't have told you what those differences were, but there are a great many, since they are in fact different species.

Can you describe your book as an item on a menu?

I'd like to think that it would be something unpretentious, nourishing, warm and comforting. Something homemade, and simple. Freshly made bread, perhaps, with a touch of salt.

https://www.bookpage.com/interviews/chloe-dalton-interview-raising-hare/

Reviews

Raising Hare by Chloe Dalton

Woman meets Leveret

Burnt out by the London rat race, the writer retreats to the countryside where a chance encounter changes her life.

By Edward Posnett

A brief survey of my one-year-old's bookshelf reveals a plethora of books about animals: crocodiles, cows, sheep and rabbits (so many rabbits). In truth these creatures are humans in disguise, or at least they embody qualities that are distinctly human; it is purely in their surface -- their fur or scales or hair -- that they resemble animals. As John Berger wrote back in 1980, they are but "human puppets", creatures whom we ventriloquise. Like animals in zoos, or large mice inhabited by underpaid and hot theme-park workers, they represent not our proximity, but our estrangement from what Berger calls "the first circle of what surrounded man", that is animals. Talk about ruining a bedtime story, John.

The cover and endpapers of Chloe Dalton's debut, Raising Hare (beautifully illustrated by Denise Nestor) at first seem to resemble these children's books: there are no rabbits, but hares, doing what hares do: inspecting berries, leaping, boxing, feeding young and gazing outward, apparently, towards the reader. The story of this excellent book is in one sense familiar: a narrator, experiencing a rupture or crisis, is transformed through a magical encounter with a "wild" creature, a hare. But there is much more going on here. As hare and narrator enter into conversation, their strange dialogue begins to shed light on our relationship with our non-human neighbours, bringing into question assumptions about control, consent, boundaries and autonomy. Unlike my daughter's books, this is a sustained and patient attempt to cross the species abyss, and to see the world through the hare's eyes.

The setting is Dalton's home, a restored stone barn situated somewhere in the English countryside (as with so much in this book, there is a deliberate elision of personal detail and we do not know exactly where). During the pandemic she retreated here from London, distancing herself from her work in the city as a well-connected political adviser (the book's acknowledgments feature William Hague and Angelina Jolie). For all that the she lionises her work (she writes, with little irony, that she would risk death for her political masters), she is conscious of its costs: severed relationships, deracination and hyper-vigilance. Dalton relishes the high-status tightrope, but is not too sure where the exit points are.

Dalton has a zoologist's eye for detail and a poet's sensitivity to language.

Enter the leveret, a baby hare, magical interloper and harbinger of transformation. She finds the creature lying on a country track outside her home, seemingly abandoned. "Its forepaws were pressed tightly together, fringed in fur the colour of bone and overlapping as if for comfort." From the outset, Dalton is conflicted about whether to rescue the hare and take her into her home. She relents, though she places certain restrictions on their relationship: she does not name the animal, tries not to touch it, and does not, except briefly, confine it

(it can leave the house through a specially constructed flap). Over the course of the book they develop a remarkable relationship with its own language; not, of course, a human language, but one of gestures, movements and exhalations (hares, we learn, emit soft, puff-like sounds). Dalton has a zoologist's eye for detail and a poet's sensitivity to language; she conjures the beauty, the allure and variation of the hare's sounds, mouth, eyes and fur, which changes with the seasons and marks the passage of time. Her language is shot with such intense tenderness and emotion that sometimes I paused, put down my pencil and asked myself: what are we actually talking about here? Are we talking about a hare? Yet the challenge of this book, or rather its invitation, is to temper parental assumptions and take Dalton's language as it comes; to imagine and appreciate both that a leveret is not a child, and its care can be as intense and meaningful as care for a child.

It was the author Michael Pollan who asked, of our relationship with plants: who is domesticating whom? It's a question that's relevant here. The hare is clearly altered: she takes powdered milk, munches coriander and enters and leaves a human domus, deriving both protection and companionship. So too Dalton, this busy professional who hare-proofs her home, sacrifices her garden plants, discovers a sense of connection to the local landscape and reevaluates her past. Theirs is a mutual dance, one without a leader, and indeed it's hard not to draw contrasts with the working culture of the place in which Dalton forged her career, Westminster. There is very little irony in this book; it possesses a dream-like quality, and often reads as a fable of metamorphosis. It is full of binaries: city v country; tame v wild; frenetic v still; before v after hare; binaries that are seductive and alluring but which perhaps reflect our own desires more than the messy realities of the Anthropocene (or indeed the painful and drawn-out process of personal change). "[Affection for an animal] has an innocence and purity of its own," Dalton writes in a finely crafted section of the book that betrays her training as a speechwriter. But is this true? All relationships, whether human or non-human, contain darkness. Even relationships of care have their own shadow, yet in this tale darkness is an external, almost archetypal, force; the machine, the city, work, the past.

Each year there appear new books which fuse stories of personal transformation and non-human encounters whether with whales, octopuses, birds and such like. What would Berger have made of these stories -- and our appetite for them? I think he might have critiqued the ease with which they flourish within those market systems which he excoriated for marginalising animals in the first place. But maybe he would have appreciated this book's urge to restore a sense of the sacred, to meet animals on their own terms, and rewild the human imagination.

Gale In Context: Global Issues,
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